

Clinical Psychosis: Grounding the Paranormal

In *Zero Sum*, the paranormal is not magical; it is a manifestation of severe clinical psychology, environmental poisoning, and systemic stress. The human mind simply breaks under the weight of the Paradigm Shift.

1. Mass Psychogenic Illness (MPI)

The entities known as *The Harvesters* are not supernatural demons. In reality, they are regular, minimum-wage human Repo-Men and Riot Police executing corporate mandates. - **The Delusion:** The unmedicated, collective trauma of society—combined with the heavy neurotoxic smog that blankets the Spire—triggers a shared psychosis (Folie à Deux / MPI). - **The Visuals:** The human mind refuses to process the reality of their cruelty. As a defense mechanism, it mentally censors these enforcers into terrifying, surreal “Fratzen” (distorted, nightmarish faces). The horror is the brain protecting itself from the mundane reality of human evil.

2. Clinical Prosopagnosia (Face-Blindness)

The aesthetic of faceless, shadowy figures is directly tied to the mechanics of trauma and empathy collapse. - **Mechanic:** As a character’s Trauma score increases, the empathy and recognition centers of their brain begin to shut down, inducing stress-induced prosopagnosia. - **Gameplay Effect:** Characters literally lose the ability to recognize human faces. At high Trauma levels, the GM can force players to roll an Observation check simply to distinguish their own allies from enemies in chaotic situations. Everyone becomes a shadowy, featureless liability. Paranoia becomes mechanical.

3. The Fracture Table (Based on the DSM-5)

A “Fracture” is not a magical curse; it is a clinical neurological collapse. When a character pushes their luck too far or maxes out their Trauma, they roll on the Fracture Table for real-world symptoms:

- **Tachycardia & Tremors:** Heart rate explodes, hands shake uncontrollably. *-20 to all precision and combat checks.*
- **Auditory Exclusion:** Temporary stress-induced deafness. *The GM may no longer speak aloud to the player and must communicate with them strictly via written notes for the duration of the encounter.*
- **Fugue State:** Dissociative amnesia. *The character loses memory of the last 10 minutes. The player must act as if they have no idea why they are in their current situation or who fired the first shot.*
- **Hyperventilation Syndrome:** Stamina recovery drops to zero. *The character must spend a full turn attempting to regulate their breathing using a specialized (and expensive) corporate inhaler.*